headsman, who appeared to have seen no less than eighty winters. Babur mentions that his mother too was alive, beyond the age of a hundred. He heard the story that a few of her cousins had gone to Hindustan with Tīmūr Beg's army when he had raised the flag of Islam at Delhi in AD 1398. Dikh-kat alone had ninety-six descendants from her. They were her grandchildren, great-grandchildren and grandchildren's grandchildren. She goes on to count those dead, and the number as told by her was no less than a couple of hundred. Now her grandchild's grandson was a strong twenty-five-year-old man. She chuckled talking of his youth mentioning the deep dark beard he had then.

While staying in Dikh-kat, barefooted excursions among the mountains became a routine for Babur. By doing so for long, his feet had turned immune to the piercing sharp stones. During one such wandering, sometime between afternoon and evening prayers, Babur saw a cow going down a narrow, badly defined road. Babur said to Khwāja Asadu'l-lāh, 'I wonder which way that road will be going; keep your eye on that cow; don't lose the cow till you know where the road comes out.' [*] Khwāja Asadu'l-lāh then cracked a joke. He said, 'If the cow loses her way, what becomes of us?'

Babur chuckled and then they moved ahead ignoring the cow, cracking more of the lighter jokes.

Things had begun to change in Babur's life. After a series of prolonged raids and fights, his life resembled that of a wandering vagrant's. And then in the winters many of Babur's soldiers asked for leave to visit Andijān. Perhaps, they felt sense in their demand for this was the period devoid of wars. While the party had come to seek the leave, Qāsim Beg with much insistence said, 'As these men are going, send something special of your own *wear* by them to Jahāngīr Mīrzā.' Babur cherished this idea so much that he sent his ermine cap as a gesture. Interestingly, Qāsim Beg even urged, 'What harm would there be if you sent something for Taṃbal also?' Hearing this appeal Babur wore a frown for obvious reasons. But for the respect, Babur held for his every advice, very unwillingly he sent Taṃbal a large broadsword which Nuyān Kūkūldāsh had made for himself in Samarkand. In the very next year, this would be the same sword dancing around to vanquish Babur. Now, in a matter of few days his maternal grandmother, Aīsān-daulat Begum arrived in Dikh-kat. She had stayed back in Samarkand with the families and a few households.